Windows 11 Version 26H2

The Windows 11 2026 Update: Overview, Comparison and Feature Guide

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Contents

- 1. Overview
- 2. Differences between 26H2 and 25H2
- 3. Why upgrade to 26H2
- 4. Features by category
- 5. Removed features
- 6. Summary

1. Overview

Windows 11, version 26H2 (the Windows 11 2026 Update) is the annual feature update for Windows 11. It is delivered as a small **enablement package** to eligible devices running Windows 11 version 25H2 or 24H2. An enablement package is a lightweight update that activates features already included in the operating system through earlier monthly updates.

Because versions 24H2, 25H2 and 26H2 share one servicing branch, installing 26H2 works much like a monthly update: a small download and a single restart in most cases.

How to get it: go to Settings > Windows Update. To receive it early, turn on "Get the latest updates as soon as they're available". Organisations can deploy it through Windows Autopatch, the Microsoft 365 admin center and other update tools. Devices on Windows 11 26H1 are not eligible.

Rollout note: Microsoft may place safeguard holds on devices with known compatibility issues during the phased rollout. The first Patch Tuesday for 26H2 is 13 October 2026.

2. Differences between 26H2 and 25H2

There is very little technical difference. 26H2 adds no surface-level features that are not also rolling out to 25H2 and 24H2.

Area	25H2	26H2
Delivery	Enablement package	Enablement package
Codebase	Shared servicing branch	Same shared servicing branch

Area	25H2	26H2
Features	Some features shipped switched off	Some of those features are on by default (mainly commercial devices)
Support lifecycle	Earlier support clock	Support lifecycle resets on install
Build number	26200.x	26300.x (per press reports)

Bug fixes ship in the same update for all three versions, so moving to 26H2 does not fix a problem by itself.

3. Why upgrade to 26H2

- **Longer support.** 24H2 Home and Pro reach end of updates on 13 October 2026. Installing 26H2 restarts the support window.
- **Low risk and low downtime.** Single restart, shared platform, reduced validation effort.
- **Defaults enabled for organisations.** Windows settings backup, app-specific taskbar actions and File Explorer enhancements are turned on by default for commercial devices.
- **Security and recovery gains.** Administrator protection, built-in Sysmon, point-in-time restore and post-quantum cryptography APIs.
- **Consistency.** Same management, security and update experience across supported releases.

Reality check: for consumers already fully updated on 25H2, the visible change is small. The main benefit is the longer support period.

4. Features by category

Many of these features already arrived through monthly updates on 24H2 and 25H2. 26H2 activates and consolidates them. Availability can depend on hardware, licensing and policy.

4.1 Enabled by default in 26H2 (commercial devices)

Feature	Description
Windows settings backup	Preserves supported Windows settings and Microsoft Store app lists for recovery and device replacement. Existing admin policies are honoured.
App-specific taskbar actions	Common app actions are available directly from taskbar experiences.
File Explorer enhancements	Navigation and usability improvements previously held behind temporary commercial controls.

4.2 Security and sign-in

Feature	Description
Administrator protection	Just-in-time admin privileges with profile separation. Off by default; enable with Intune or Group Policy.
Built-in Sysmon	Captures system events for threat detection into Windows Event Log. Off by default.
Smart App Control	Can be turned on or off without a clean install.
Passkey plugin managers	Use or save passkeys in third-party credential managers. PIN support for security keys.
Windows Hello ESS	Enhanced Sign-in Security supports compatible peripheral fingerprint sensors, including on desktops and Copilot+ PCs.
Driver security	Default trust for cross-signed drivers is removed. WHCP drivers and an allow list remain. Compatibility is audited for at least 100 hours and three restarts before enforcement.
Post-quantum cryptography	API support for ML-KEM and ML-DSA (FIPS 203 and 204) via CNG and .NET.
Secure batch processing	Optional mode that stops batch files changing while they run.

4.3 Device management, deployment and recovery

Feature	Description
Autopilot device association	Identifies trusted devices before enrollment; enables device-targeted policies and OOBE customisation.
First sign-in restore	Settings and Store app list restore for Entra hybrid joined devices, Cloud PCs and multi-user setups. Enterprise State Roaming managed via backup policies.
Point-in-time restore	Rolls back apps, settings and personal files to a recent automatic restore point.

Feature	Description
Quick machine recovery	One-time remediation scan; directs users to other recovery options if no fix is available. Off on managed devices unless enabled.
Preinstalled app removal	Remove additional MSIX/APPX apps by package family name via Group Policy.

4.4 User experience

Area	What's new
File Explorer	AI actions (edit images, summarize documents; summarize needs Microsoft 365 and Copilot licence), quick actions on Home hover for work or school accounts, more archive formats (uu, cpio, xar, nupkg), saved View and Sort preferences, voice typing for renaming, faster Home.
Windows Search	Preview results without opening, better typo and partial-name handling for apps, clearer result types, automatic indexing of frequently used folders (Settings > Privacy & security > Search).
Start menu	Scrollable All section, category and grid views, responsive layout, selectable size, show or hide Pinned, Recent and All.
Taskbar	Position at bottom, top, left or right; smaller taskbar option; monitor AI agents (Researcher in Copilot first).
Camera	Multi-App Camera lets several apps use the camera at once; Basic Camera mode for troubleshooting. Configured via Group Policy.
Bluetooth and USB	Better Bluetooth LE Audio, calls, mic mute sync and reconnect after hibernation; more reliable USB4 docks and hubs on resume.
Windows Update	Fewer restarts by installing eligible updates with the monthly security update; device returns to sleep after updating even if sleep is set to Never.

4.5 Accessibility

- **Magnifier:** clearer screen reader announcements, exact zoom percentage, adjustable zoom increments, full-screen colour tint.
- **Narrator:** Braille Viewer, improved Word navigation, more control over announced control details and order.
- **Voice access:** natural language commands on supported Copilot+ PCs, French, German, Spanish and Korean support, Voice Isolation.

4.6 IT administration

- **Task Manager:** NPU usage columns (NPU, NPU Engine, NPU Dedicated and Shared Memory), GPU neural engines on the Performance page, and an Isolation column showing AppContainer apps.

5. Removed features

WMIC (Windows Management Instrumentation Command-line) has been removed from Windows 11 version 24H2 and above and is no longer available as a Feature on Demand. Use PowerShell or other management tools instead.

6. Summary

- 26H2 is a **small, safe enablement-package update** with no major redesign.
- It **activates features** delivered through monthly updates and **resets the support lifecycle**.
- The biggest value is in **security, recovery and admin tooling**.
- **Upgrade if** you are on 24H2 (support ends 13 October 2026) or want the newest supported version with minimal effort.
- If you are on a fully updated 25H2, the visible change is small, but there is little reason to delay.

Sources: Microsoft Learn (What's new in Windows 11, version 26H2), Microsoft Windows Experience Blog, Microsoft Support, and press coverage from Thurrott, Windows Central, BleepingComputer and Windows Latest. Build number and rollout details come from press reports and may change.